SCROLLING PAST DEMOCRACY

RECONNECTING YOUTH WITH CREDIBLE JOURNALISM

WHAT IS THE ISSUE?

To scroll or not to scroll? This is a question that plagues Gen Z on the daily. Around every 15 seconds to be exact. As today's youth becomes more reliant on **short-form media for news**, risk of misinformation spread goes up.

When flashy headlines earn virality over reliable sources, the urge to share heightens. If left unchecked, widespread misinformation will **threaten joirnalism's ability** to inform citizens and prepare the next generation for active democratic participation.

WHAT IS FAKE NEWS AND WHY IS IT SPREAD?

- Fake news refers to **misleading content** which is **disguised** as news media. Social media trends usually use misleading headlines to **grab viewers attention** for engagement, even when the headline **does not match** the inner content.
- When choosing what to share on social media, youth are most often doing so for **gratification** in the form of popularity and **social utility.**
- When **misleading headlines** generate the **most engagement**, youth are **more inclined to share** the fake, over-exagerrated article over the reliable source.





RISKS OF MISINFORMATION SPREAD IN GEN Z

- Youth today indicate a **"news-finds-me"** mindset in which they rely on their social media algorithm for news. Meaning they are **more likely to read a fake headline** shared by their peer than an article by a credible journalist.
- Reliance on one's personal feed for news increases **polarization** and **echo chambers**, as algorithms promote content within their existing viewpoint.
- The combination of only seeing one side along with many social media sources being false, Gen Z risks being **extremely misinformed** with current events.





HOW DOES THIS EFFECT ME?

Gen Z turning away from credible journalism does not just put their own well-being in jeopardy, but puts the **entire larger democratic system at risk.**

Social media echo chambers reinfornce in the **"us vs. them" mentality**, which risks journalism's function to foster meaningful **civic dialouge** between parties.

Youth are the **leaders of tomorrow**. As short-form news threatens to tear a generation apart, the **future of our country** as we know it is at just as much **at risk.**



HOW CAN WE INCREASE GEN Z'S NEWS QUALITY CONSUMPTION?

We propose the implementation of the **News Credibility Rewards Program.** This is a gamified incentive program attached to social networking sites in which we will work together with reliable media accounts to rewards users for sharing, engaging with, and verifying credible journalism.

Instead of likes and shares driving visibility for misleading headlines, **badges, points, and recognition** are attached to posts that come from **verified, fact-checked sources.**

WHY THIS SOLUTION REALLY WORKS

- **Tackles the root cause:** While many existing solutions (such as Media Literacy) simply teach Gen Z to recognize fake news, it does not address why they spread misinformation in the first place (social validation).
  - Credibility Rewards directly channels the desire for social validation into positive behavior: youth gain the same gratification, but tied to truth rather than clicks.
- **Aligns With Gen Z's Culture of Gamification & Peer Validation:** Youth are already motivated by existing social media badges such as Snapchat Streaks and Profile Frames earned through consistency and participation.
  - This system makes accuracy just as rewarding as virality.
- **Supports Journalism's Democratic Functions:**
  - **Informs citizens:** Verified journalism recieves a boost in the algorithm.
  - **Fosters dialouge**: Youth are forced to engage with credible sources, which often explains both sides.
  - **Educates for democracy:** Builds habits of credibility-focused news sharing.